

Slim Asus U36 gets better hardware

The 19mm thin 13-inch U36 ultraportable will soon run on a standard voltage Core i5 processor and still last up to 11.5 hours on a single charge.

Router test



Dlink DSL2750U

the price range varied from ₹1,699 to ₹2,550, these were pretty easy to slot into a single category.

The Buffalo WBMH-HP-GN impressed us with its compact dimensions and attractive looks in stark contrast to the rather bulky and plain looking Digisol DG-BG4011N. The Dlink DSL2750U was the only one that didn't elicit any initial reactions owing to its rather generic look – a beige box with a single antenna. One of the issues with the Buffalo WBMH-HP-GN is the placement of the reset button on the bottom of the router. With the stand in place, the reset button gets blocked. Buffalo's interface is a little intimidating to a newbie, and while Dlink's interface looks simple at first, when one gets into the sub menus it is every bit as complicated. The SMC SMC7901WBRA2 looked nice, and is very well built, but had no indicative lights of any sort. It also featured a single LAN port.

In terms of performance, none of these ADSL routers really impressed. The Digisol DG-BG4011N was, by far, the most disappointing. It failed quite a few tests in zone three, and while moving between zone two and three, could not maintain wireless coverage to our test notebook. While there wasn't much sense in awarding a winner amongst just three devices, we realise that many of you will be looking for an ADSL router. If so, the Dlink DSL2750U should be your best bet, it's really cheap, and does a fair job. We're awarding it our Digit Best Buy.

UP TO ₹2,500: ENTRY TO A WIRELESS HOME

Surprisingly we found this category quite hotly contested, and some very decent options emerged. Normally, good wireless routers are priced at the 4,000-Rupee mark, but it seems competition has hammered MRPs into shape. There were six routers in this category – two from Linksys (Cisco), and one each from Belkin, Buffalo, Dlink and Netgear. Unsurprisingly, the only router supporting the older 802.11g protocol was in this category the Netgear WGR614. Normally, you'd be tempted to dismiss a G-router as a fossil, but this model held its own.

Looks and features

The Dlink DIR-524 was a simple looking black box, with a single

antenna, while both the Linksys WRT120N and E1000 have the same futuristic tapering shape with a wide halo-like rim on the top that is reminiscent of something out of a George Lucas film. Both these routers, like all other Linksys devices do not have antennas – Linksys relies on internal antennae to do the job of transmitting wireless signals. One thing we noticed with the Linksys WRT120N as with other entry-level Linksys routers was that any firmware changes take 10 to 15 seconds to apply. The E2000 and E3000 are faster, with no message like “please wait for 10 sec”. Also rather peculiarly when transferring data the WRT120N makes a slight sound, like as if a small fan inside were speeding up, though we doubt there would be a fan in the small housing. This is only when data is being transferred/streamed wirelessly and not while performing low bandwidth tasks like browsing. Both the WRT120N and E1000 get quite hot during operation, though not alarmingly so.

Like all Buffalo routers, the WCR-HP-GN was really slim, though it has a grey colour, as opposed to their de facto black. Also, the antenna was a pole type one and long, in contrast to the typical flat, shorter antennae seen on most of their routers. The Netgear WGR614 is their typical design with a white plastic body

and transparent plastic trim around three sides, and a slightly curvy body with a single antenna. Belkin's Basic was a small router but follows the same design as the other Belkin routers, with a single LED on the front capable of multiple colours conveying all



Belkin Basic

you need to know. While it's cute, it's also little more than a simple looking grey box and with the base being part of the unit, one cannot set this up flat on a table nor wall mount it. Belkin has chosen a menu system for all their routers and we must say it's a positive move – everything looks much better laid out and a lot more intuitive and definitely more newbie friendly.

Performance

The Linksys WRT120N showed an interesting spike in data

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